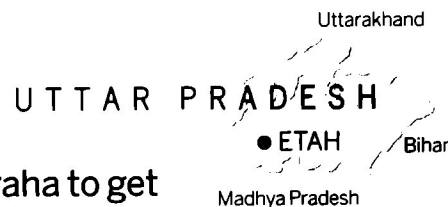


# Soul Satyagrahi



A humble farmer turns to the Gandhian way of satyagraha to get basic public services like water, healthcare and roads for his region



THE INDEFATIGABLE  
DAYARAM

SANJAY SONKAR

| By Farzand Ahmed |

People think he is a madman, officials respect him for his love of people's causes and politicians shun him for his threats of prolonged satyagrahas—anywhere, anytime. Meet Dayaram Singh, 58, a marginal farmer from Nagla Mira village of Etah, 250 km from Lucknow. To get a canal, he met the Etah district magistrate 129 times between 1983-1986, who responded only after former Lok Sabha Speaker Balram Jakhar wrote to him. Similarly in 1997, the water supply stopped in his area after which he approached the then Union minister of state for rural development Uttambhai Patel. He had to resort to hunger strike to get the administration to dig wells for access to non-salty water. It took 11 satyagrahas for him to get water, a seven-bed hospital and roads.

Recently, Singh staged a dharna under the statue of Mahatma Gandhi near the Uttar Pradesh Assembly, again espousing farmers' causes. Says he: "Whenever I see Gandhiji's statue, I talk to it and ask it if swaraj will come and if the poor will get the freedom that Mahatma Gandhi had promised."

The local administration respects Singh and ticket checkers allow him to travel free to Lucknow. Even the local police have allowed him free travel by bus. In his fight for citizens' rights, the frail farmer has come close to death due to hunger and dehydration. Just last month, he collapsed and was rushed to hospital while on a strike. He also has been jailed many times.

As a youth, Singh had a modest dream—to become a peon in a government office. In 1971, he started chasing his dream which helped him get in touch with many national-level leaders, though none could help him get the job. He then came up with the alternative plan of helping people in the region. Since then he has not looked back. He has neither political ambitions nor any leanings as he feels that a political position not only corrupts but also makes people arrogant.

Now Singh has found a permanent problem to fight against—saline water, which is neither good for drinking nor for irrigation. A possible solution is to dig deeper, which, the 'mad' farmer knows, will keep him busy with the authorities for quite some time. ■